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LETTERS TO MY SON

On Discipline

16 letters

Father

A father's letters, worth keeping.

A word before you begin

My son,

Of all I could leave you, the power to command yourself is the greatest. These letters are on the quiet war a man wages with himself — and how he wins it.

Read one a day. Sit with it. Let it change one small thing in how you live.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Do now what you would otherwise do badly later, in a hurry.

Whatever is worth doing is worth doing well — and what is worth doing well is worth your full attention now.

Half-done is a debt you pay twice.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Idleness is the most exhausting thing a young man can do.

A mind with nothing to chase turns and devours itself.

Give it a worthy hunt.

Tire yourself on purpose, or be tired by accident.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

No man is free who is a slave to his own body.

The appetite you cannot govern governs you. Master the small wants or serve them forever.

Rule yourself, or be ruled by yourself.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Pursue your aim relentlessly; let no solvable difficulty rob you of your courage.

Most men quit at the first wall, never knowing the door was ten feet to the left.

Outlast the obstacle; it is more tired than you are.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Good manners are won with more effort than almost anything, and matter more than most things.

Talent gets you noticed; how you treat people decides whether you are kept.

Work on your manner the way other men work on their craft.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Do one thing at a time, and give it the whole of you.

The scattered man finishes nothing and calls it being busy.

Single-task like your future depends on it, because it does.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

No man is free who cannot command himself.

The appetite you will not govern becomes the master you must obey.

Rule the small wants, or serve them all your life.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Pursue your aim and let no surmountable obstacle stop you.

Most men turn back one step from the opening in the wall.

Outlast the difficulty; it tires before you do.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The body grown soft makes the will grow soft with it.

Comfort, taken daily, quietly unfits a man for hard things.

Choose some hardship on purpose, before life chooses it for you.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Whatever is worth doing is worth the whole of your effort.

Half-done work is a debt that returns to be paid twice.

Finish it well now, or meet it again later.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Set yourself a rule and keep it when no one is watching.

Character is what remains when the audience leaves.

Be the same man in private as in the square.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Begin to be now what you wish to become.

You are not waiting on a better day; you are avoiding the first hard step.

Take the step while it is still only one step.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Application can mend almost any natural defect.

Demosthenes drilled against his own stammer until it became eloquence.

Pick the flaw you hate most and work it daily.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The willing are led by fate; the unwilling are dragged.

Either you choose the hard road, or it chooses you and adds chains.

Walk it on your own feet.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Work, even when you need not, so your children see what built the house.

Inherited ease without inherited effort rots a family in one generation.

Let them watch you earn; that is the lesson money cannot buy.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Small efforts, repeated, do what great bursts cannot.

The drip outlasts the flood and carves the stone.

Trust the daily small thing over the grand gesture.

Yours faithfully,

Father

Keep going

If these served you, there is more.

- A new letter every day — @letters_to_son_eng
- The weekly letter — comment LETTERS to join.
- The full collection and printed keepsakes — coming soon.

Carry these well. One day you may write your own.

Yours faithfully,

Father